

INTEGRITY RECORDS

AS YOURSELF

*Loving God, Your Neighbor, and the Self
Christ Died to Redeem*

*“You shall love the Lord your God with your whole heart, with your whole soul,
and with all your mind... You shall love your neighbor as yourself.”*

MATTHEW 22:37-39

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INTRODUCTION

The Command Inside the Command

“You shall love the Lord your God with your whole heart, with your whole soul, and with all your mind. This is the greatest and first commandment. The second is like it; You shall love your neighbor as yourself.”

MATTHEW 22:37-39

Most teaching on this passage stops at the neighbor. Love God first, love people second — and that is certainly true and certainly the emphasis Jesus intends. But tucked inside the second commandment is a small phrase most of us read past without ever stopping to ask what it actually requires: as yourself.

Jesus doesn't say love your neighbor instead of yourself, or love your neighbor and ignore yourself entirely. He gives a measure — as yourself — which quietly assumes that a certain right, ordered love of self is not only permitted but necessary, or the measurement itself makes no sense. You cannot use a broken ruler to measure something else accurately. If self-love is genuinely absent or distorted, love of neighbor built on that same measure will be distorted too.

The second commandment doesn't abolish self-love. It assumes it, and asks you to extend the same measure outward.

This book is not permission to make yourself the center of your own devotion — that would collapse the whole order Jesus just laid out, with God first and neighbor close behind. It is an honest look at the middle term most of us skip: the self God made, the self Christ died to redeem, and the self so many artists have quietly learned to treat as the one person in the room who doesn't need love at all.

CHAPTER ONE

With Your Whole Heart

Before anything can be said about loving neighbor or self rightly, the first commandment has to be allowed to stay first. Whole heart, whole soul, all your mind — Jesus doesn't leave a corner unclaimed. This is deliberate. Every distortion covered later in this book, including the distortions of self-love, traces back to a first love that has gone partial.

An artist whose whole heart genuinely belongs to God has a settled place to stand while asking harder questions about self-care, self-worth, and self-neglect. An artist whose devotion to God is partial will inevitably try to fill the remainder with something else — often either an inflated self-regard or a starved one, because both are attempts to solve, apart from God, a problem only He was ever meant to solve.

Why the order matters

Loving God first is not a hierarchy that diminishes the other two loves. It's the condition that makes them sane. Self-love untethered from love of God tends toward vanity or despair, depending on the day. Self-love properly ordered beneath love of God has somewhere honest to land: you are worth loving because God, who cannot be wrong about anything, already values you enough to command it.

“We love because he first loved us.”

1 JOHN 4:19

Every other kind of love in this book — of neighbor, of self — is downstream of this one. Get this one only partially right, and the other two will inherit the same partiality.

REFLECTION

Where, honestly, is your love of God currently partial rather than whole?

What would change in how you treat yourself if that love were allowed to become whole first?

CHAPTER TWO

The Forgotten Clause

It's worth asking plainly why “as yourself” gets skipped so often in how this verse is taught. Part of the answer is legitimate caution — a culture already saturated with self-focus doesn't obviously need another reason to think about itself more. But caution can tip into avoidance, and many believers, especially those pouring themselves out in ministry, music, or any public calling, have quietly absorbed the idea that any attention to their own well-being is itself a kind of selfishness to be repented of.

That is not what the text says. The command assumes a baseline: you already, as a matter of course, feed yourself, protect yourself, forgive yourself for small failures, and want good things for your own future. Jesus takes that baseline and says, now extend exactly that same instinct outward, toward your neighbor. If the baseline itself has eroded — if you no longer feed, protect, forgive, or hope for yourself — the command doesn't have healthy material left to extend.

You cannot extend a love you have quietly stopped believing you deserve.

What gets lost when this clause is forgotten

- Neighbor-love starts running on guilt and obligation rather than genuine overflow.
- Rest starts to feel like theft rather than stewardship.
- Self-criticism gets relabeled as humility, when it has actually become something closer to contempt.

Recovering this clause is not a project in self-indulgence. It's a project in restoring the actual measuring stick Jesus handed us, so that what gets extended to other people is something whole rather than something already running on empty.

REFLECTION

Have you ever treated attention to your own well-being as something to feel guilty about?

What baseline of care for yourself has quietly eroded that you'd never allow to erode for someone you love?

CHAPTER THREE

Self-Neglect Disguised as Humility

Not all self-neglect looks like neglect. Some of the most thorough self-neglect in Christian circles is dressed up convincingly as humility — the artist who never rests because resting feels like pride, the believer who cannot receive a compliment without deflecting it, the servant who has quietly decided that wanting anything for themselves is evidence of a heart not fully surrendered.

This can sound spiritual. It is often something else entirely: a self-contempt that has learned to speak the language of surrender fluently enough to avoid examination. Genuine humility is an accurate view of yourself before God — not an artificially low one. Paul's instruction is to think of yourself with sober judgment, not with reflexive self-erasure.

“For by the grace given me I say to every one of you: Do not think of yourself more highly than you ought, but rather think of yourself with sober judgment.”

ROMANS 12:3

Sober judgment cuts both ways

Sober judgment is not the same as low judgment. It corrects inflated self-regard, yes, but it corrects deflated self-regard just as firmly, because both are inaccurate. An artist who constantly minimizes their own gifts, needs, and limits in the name of humility is not more spiritual than one who is honest about them. They are simply wrong in the opposite direction.

- Ask whether your self-denial is actually serving someone, or simply avoiding an honest reckoning with your own worth.
- Notice when 'I don't need that' is really 'I don't believe I'm allowed to need that.'
- Genuine humility can receive care as easily as it gives it.

REFLECTION

Where has self-neglect in your life been quietly relabeled as humility?

What would sober judgment — not inflated, not deflated — actually say about your own worth right now?

CHAPTER FOUR

Made in His Image

Any honest theology of self-love has to start further back than personal feelings about personal worth. It starts at creation, where the value of a human being was settled before a single choice, achievement, or failure entered the picture.

“So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them.”

GENESIS 1:27

This is not a metaphor added later for encouragement. It is the stated basis for human worth throughout Scripture — worth rooted in whose image is stamped on a person, not in what that person has produced, achieved, or overcome. An artist's worth, by this measure, was never actually up for renegotiation based on streaming numbers, chart position, or how the last release performed.

“For you created my inmost being; you knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise you because I am fearfully and wonderfully made; your works are wonderful, I know that full well.”

PSALM 139:13-14

You do not have to earn the value that was assigned to you before you did anything at all.

Why this matters practically

A self-love built on this foundation is remarkably stable, because it doesn't fluctuate with performance. A self-love built on achievement, audience response, or comparison to other artists will always be exactly as stable as the last data point. Recovering “as yourself” starts here — not with self-esteem as a psychological technique, but with an accurate theological memory of whose image you actually carry.

REFLECTION

How much of your current sense of worth is tied to performance rather than to being made in God's image?

What would it look like this week to treat your own worth as already settled, rather than still being decided?

CHAPTER FIVE

You Cannot Pour From an Empty Cup

Scripture doesn't use this exact modern phrase, but the principle behind it is everywhere. Jesus withdrew to lonely places to pray, even at the height of His ministry's demand. Elijah, after his greatest public victory, was fed and allowed to sleep before he was given his next assignment — his exhaustion was treated as a fact to be addressed, not a spiritual failure to be shamed.

"Then he lay down under the bush and fell asleep. All at once an angel touched him and said, 'Get up and eat.'"

1 KINGS 19:5

Notice what God did not say to Elijah in that moment. He did not rebuke him for needing rest and food before he could hear the still small voice that was coming. He simply provided it, twice, before addressing anything else. Restoration came before revelation, because an empty, exhausted person cannot receive what's being offered even if it arrives right on schedule.

What this looks like for an artist

- Protecting actual rest, not just the absence of scheduled work, on a rhythm you keep regardless of demand.
- Treating your own spiritual, emotional, and physical depletion as information to act on, not evidence of weak faith.
- Asking, before saying yes to another obligation, whether you currently have anything left to actually give.

God fed Elijah before He spoke to him. Provision, for you, may need to come in that same order.

Loving your neighbor as yourself was never meant to be sustained by a self running on empty. The measure Jesus gives assumes a self that has been fed enough to have something real to extend.

REFLECTION

Where in your life are you currently pouring from a cup you haven't allowed to be refilled?

What would it look like to receive provision for yourself the way Elijah did — before, not instead of, the next assignment?

CHAPTER SIX

The Artist's Version

Every principle in this book takes on a sharper edge inside a music career specifically, because the pressures of that career are custom-built to erode healthy self-regard from several directions at once.

Comparison

An artist's feed is a constant stream of other people's highlight reels, chart positions, and applause. Comparison, left unchecked, quietly teaches an artist to measure their own worth against a moving target they will never permanently win, which is a very different thing than the fixed, settled worth Genesis 1:27 describes.

People-pleasing dressed as ministry

Because an artist's calling genuinely does involve serving an audience, it becomes easy to justify an unlimited erosion of personal limits as simply 'what the calling requires.' Real ministry to others and unexamined people-pleasing can look identical from the outside, and only an honest self-love can tell the difference from the inside.

The performance of wellness

Public artists often feel pressure to appear consistently well, consistently grateful, consistently unbothered — a performance of wellness that can become its own form of self-neglect, because it forbids the artist from ever being honestly not okay in front of the very people who might actually help.

- Name one place comparison currently sets your sense of worth instead of your identity in Christ.
- Name one 'yes' that was really people-pleasing wearing the language of ministry.
- Name one person safe enough to tell the truth to when the performance of wellness isn't true that day.

REFLECTION

Which of these three — comparison, people-pleasing, or performed wellness — is currently costing you the most?

Who in your life could you actually be honest with about that cost?

CHAPTER SEVEN

Ordered Love

None of this book is an argument for making yourself the center. Jesus was precise about the order: God first, with everything you have; neighbor second, using yourself as the honest measure. Self-love was never meant to be the destination. It was meant to be the calibrated instrument that makes the second commandment possible to obey accurately.

An artist who loves God first has a settled center that doesn't require self-focus or self-erasure to maintain. Out of that settled center, a right regard for the self God made becomes possible — not preoccupation, not indulgence, just an honest accounting of a person worth caring for. And out of that honest accounting, love for neighbor finally has something real and whole to draw from, rather than running on the fumes of guilt or obligation.

Get the order right, and self-love stops being a danger and becomes exactly what it was always meant to be: the measuring stick, not the destination.

This is the ordered love this whole book has been pointing toward: God loved with everything you have, yourself regarded honestly enough to have something real to extend, and neighbor loved with that same real thing, rather than a counterfeit assembled out of guilt. Three loves, correctly stacked, each one making the next one possible.

REFLECTION

Where in your life is the order currently reversed — self or neighbor placed ahead of God, or self erased entirely instead of rightly ordered beneath Him?

What would it look like this week to put all three back in their intended order?

CLOSING WORD

As Yourself

The measure was never meant to be complicated. Love God with everything you have. Love your neighbor the same honest way you already, quietly, know how to love yourself — feeding what is hungry, resting what is tired, forgiving what has failed, hoping well for what is still ahead. Extend that same instinct outward, and you are keeping the second commandment exactly as it was given.

If that measure has gone missing in your own life — if the self on the other end of “as yourself” has been neglected, starved, or quietly written off — that is not a footnote to fix later. It is the very thing this command assumes you will tend to, so that what you give away to everyone else is something whole.

Love the Lord your God with your whole heart. Love your neighbor as yourself. Let both halves of that sentence be true.

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